

Advocacy — A Short Guide for Trimtabs

What changes minds, what doesn't, and one way to work

Michel Garand | September 2026 | Version 0.5 | CC BY-SA 4.0

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Written to be given away. This is the short, plain-language companion to the full advocacy reference published alongside it — same findings, same figures, none of the apparatus. Read this one first. If a number matters to you, the reference (\$10) says where it comes from. A Ukrainian edition is published alongside; each is written in its own language rather than translated line by line. The Ukrainian has not yet been read by a native speaker. This document was developed with assistance from Claude (Anthropic PBC). All strategic decisions and commitments are those of the author.

Two things that happened

In 2012 a video about a warlord in central Africa was watched a hundred million times in under a week. It raised thirty million dollars. Two years later the money was gone, the warlord was still free, the sequel was watched by almost nobody, and the organisation closed.

Since 1992 a German artist has been setting small brass plaques into pavements outside the last homes of people murdered under the Nazis. A name, a birth year, a fate. "Here lived." No explanation. Each stone costs about 120 euros, paid by someone who wants it there — a neighbour, a school class, a grandchild. The family is asked first. The hundred-thousandth stone was laid in 2023. Nobody has ever made a viral video about them, and they are in dozens of countries and still going.

Hold those two side by side. One had everything advocacy is supposed to want — reach, emotion, money, urgency — and left nothing behind. The other had none of it and is still there. Most of what this guide has to say comes out of that comparison.

What advocacy is

The word is Latin: *ad-vocare*, to call someone to your aid. An advocate speaks for a person or a cause, toward people who could do something about it.

Plain version: **advocacy is trying, on purpose and together, to change what people think, feel, or do — for someone or something that cannot do it alone.**

There are three ways to do that, and most campaigns mix them without noticing:

- **Speaking for someone.** Carrying their story to people who cannot hear it themselves. Testimony. Witness.
- **Speaking to someone.** Persuading — arguments, appeals, framing, the whole toolkit of "let me convince you."
- **Showing.** Building or revealing the thing itself, and letting people draw their own conclusion.

One line to hold in wartime: advocacy that stops caring whether it is true has become propaganda, whatever it calls itself.

The toolbox

Before the pattern, the menu — what people have actually tried, in a sentence each, with the catch.

Saying it better.

- Rebuttal and fact-checking — correct the false claim. Catch: repeating a claim to deny it makes it more familiar.
- Framing — change the frame, not the facts. Catch: takes a decade and an industry.
- Moral reframing — argue in the audience's values, not your own.
- Hope first — lead with the vision, not the violation; what the human-rights field did when outrage stopped working.
- Social norms — show that the good behaviour is common. Catch: show the bad one as common and you have just normalised it.

Talking to people.

- Deep canvassing — one unhurried conversation in which the listener does most of the talking. The strongest measured, lasting shift there is. Catch: one person at a time.
- Organising — build relationships until you have power, then negotiate. You win a seat at the table, not a change of heart.
- Lobbying — access, drafting, relationships. Works, costs money, involves nobody.

Telling it.

- Testimony — carry documented suffering to those who can act. Catch: the person becomes material.
- Solutions journalism — report the responses, not only the problems. Readers feel more able and avoid the news less.
- Fiction that teaches — radio dramas, telenovelas. Works — and it is fiction, with everything that costs in trust.

- Art — image, theatre, music, made things. Shows; the viewer finishes. Carries anything.
- Satire — humour with a target. Can topple a regime; cannot be gentle.

Doing it.

- Boycott, divestment, sanctions — make complicity expensive. Refusal alone is half a method; pair it with a visible yes.
- Twinning and sponsorship — a relationship that outlasts the campaign; taking part changes minds over years.
- Litigation — change the rule instead of the attitude. Decisive where there is a rights framework to invoke.
- Building the alternative — make the new thing and let it argue. Fuller.
- Counter-mapping — change what the map shows, or what a point on it is.

Amplifying.

- Platforms and influencers — rented attention. Not a method; an amplifier that rewards the burst.
- Social marketing — advertising craft aimed at a cause. The craft transfers; the sales logic does not.

And the other side's. The firehose — see below. A toolbox that leaves it out explains nothing about the world you are working in.

What usually goes wrong

The big failures in the record — a billion-dollar anti-drug campaign that may have made things worse, the viral video above, a scare-them-straight youth programme that made kids *more* likely to offend — share four habits. Plain names.

They burst. One video, one week, one push. Then silence. The feed loves this, and the feed forgets in days.

They take. Someone's suffering becomes raw material. The person shown is a source, not a member; ethics arrives later as a consent form.

They tell. The meaning is announced — "this is what you should feel, this is what you should do." People feel the push and push back.

They never say what failure looks like. So nobody ever sees them fail, and the budget outlives the evidence.

None of these is stupid. Each is a sensible answer to the economics of campaigns. Together they produce the landscape Western audiences have already learned to scroll past.

What tends to work

The lasting successes look different, and they look different in the same way — on four continents, in movements that could not afford advertising:

- women in 1791 refusing sugar in their own kitchens, three hundred thousand households at a time, because the sugar bowl was the one political instrument they had;
- Kenyan women planting seven seedlings in 1977, then fifty million trees, each tree at once proof, income, soil, and membership;
- mothers in Buenos Aires walking the same circle every Thursday under a dictatorship until the dictatorship was gone;
- the brass stones;
- an American quilt of fifty thousand panels, each the size of a grave, each sewn by the dead person's own people — for many the only funeral that stigma allowed.

Four things they share.

They last. Years, decades. Time itself becomes the evidence. The same place, seen again, further grown.

The people shown own it. The mothers were the movement. The women sewed the panels. The family is asked before the stone. Membership, not extraction.

They show instead of arguing. A name on a stone does not explain. A tree has no caption. The viewer finishes the meaning — and a meaning you finish yourself is one you keep.

They can be counted. Trees, stones, panels, years. Something a hostile stranger can check.

Here is the finding underneath all of it, and it is not about money. A message decays. A membership act accumulates. The platforms amplify whatever you hand them — hand them a message and you get a spike and a fade; hand them an act people do themselves (my story, my bucket of ice water, my abstained sugar) and each share is itself a small demonstration. The unit you share decides everything.

One photograph measured both halves of that at once. September 2015: the picture of Alan Kurdi, a small boy drowned on a Turkish beach. Within days, daily donations to one Syria fund rose a hundredfold — and faded, the researchers found, almost as fast. But inside the fade one number went the other way: sign-ups for a regular monthly gift rose tenfold, and by the following January almost none of those people had cancelled. The burst behaved like every burst. The people it turned into members stayed.

And one from the war in Ukraine. NAFO, from 2022: thousands of strangers who donated to Ukraine's defence, got a cartoon dog for it, and have spent four years making Russian official accounts unable to post without being laughed at. Nobody organised it; nobody paid for reach; the badge was earned, not bought. The membership mechanics are the same as the stones'. The register — satire, with a target — is not, and does not travel everywhere: keep the mechanics, choose your own voice.

Why — six things the mind does

None of this is folk wisdom. Every line above sits on something psychologists have measured.

1. **Pushed people push back.** Feel a message as pressure and you defend your right to decide for yourself — sometimes by moving the other way. An adult at a lectern telling teenagers not to take drugs is a machine for producing exactly this.
2. **We warm to what we see often, unforced.** Familiarity breeds liking with no argument happening. And a real, particular person, seen again and again even at a distance, works on the mind almost like a neighbour — contact, the best-studied cure for prejudice there is. Spread the encounters out: spaced beats crammed, in memory and in advocacy. Duration's quiet engine.
3. **One person moves us; a thousand numb us.** The numbing begins at the second face. One person in the frame is not a style choice. It is a limit of the human mind.
4. **Doing changes believing.** More reliably than the other way round. Sponsor one stone, plant one tree, and your picture of yourself shifts to match. Small act, then the next.
5. **Fear without a way out shuts people down.** Threat plus a doable step moves them; threat alone makes them look away. Forty years of pictures of a helpless continent produced not action but the certainty that nothing can be done.
6. **Repetition makes things feel true.** Even lies. Especially lies. Which brings us to the other side.

The other side's method

The people working against Ukraine in the information space are not, mostly, trying to convince anyone of anything. Their method — researchers named it the firehose of falsehood — is high volume, many channels, no commitment to truth or even to consistency. Its product is not belief. It is exhaustion: the feeling that nothing can be known and nothing can be done. A great deal of what looks like Western "fatigue" is that feeling, manufactured on purpose. The firehose does not try to out-shout you. It raises everyone's friction at once until nothing can build up any more — which is why shouting back does not work.

They have also learned to buy rather than build. In 2024 a US indictment showed about ten million dollars moved through shell companies to one content firm; one commentator was on four hundred thousand dollars a month. Put that beside the stone: four hundred thousand a month for one rented voice; a hundred and twenty euros for one permanent name.

The firehose has one structural weakness. It can fake any single picture and any single story. It cannot fake the same real place, revisited, over years. A lie has to be maintained. A garden only has to be watered. Volume against volume loses; time against volume is the answer that costs nothing.

Art and marketing — carriers, not methods

Creative advocacy is what this work is now often called, so two words need clearing.

Art is demonstration's native language. It shows; the viewer finishes. But art carries whatever it is given — the same craft has served memorials and tyrannies — and it has three ways of failing: the beautiful picture of the terrible thing that lets you feel and not act; the subject turned into material for the artist's object; and plain service to a bad cause. The strongest art in the record — the quilt, the stones, theatre where the audience stops the scene and plays the alternative themselves — is art the people shown make themselves.

Marketing's discipline transfers: know your audience, test your message, be consistent. Its logic does not: bought reach, a quarterly horizon, the audience as consumers. The best-measured success in advocacy — a teen anti-smoking campaign that recouped its own cost — was marketing craft of the highest order aimed at a demonstration, not at a message.

For a room of makers: make the thing people join, not the thing about them. Test it like an advertiser, sign it like an artist, and give it away like neither.

You already have the word for this

Toloka. If you grew up with it, it needs no explaining. Neighbours arrive, the work gets done, and belonging follows the log you carried, not the speech you made. Norwegians call it dugnad, the Irish meitheal, Turks imece, Kenyans harambee, Filipinos bayanihan. The people you are trying to reach already own a version of it. That matters more than it looks: the strongest thing you can build is one where the audience's own step — follow, twin, fund, visit — is the membership, and the campaign is what those steps add up to.

One way to work — a trimtab method

What follows is one author's proposal. Keep the name or throw it away. Everything above is the record; this is one reading of it.

Start with a question, not a claim. *What if this were possible?* A claim can be rebutted. A question can only be answered — and the way to answer it is to build the thing and let time check it. What-if is the door out of two comfort zones at once: the audience's (nothing can be done, so nothing is asked of me) and the advocate's (being right is comfortable; showing and then staying quiet is not).

Think trimtab. On a big ship the rudder is too heavy to push directly. So there is a small tab on the rudder's edge — the trimtab: the water moves that, that moves the rudder, the rudder moves the ship. Don't push the audience. Place one small, true, well-made thing where the water is already moving — the town twinning, the aid group, the local newsletter, the teacher — and let the flow do the work. Carriers before crowds.

The word has a second meaning, from aircraft, and it may be the truer one here: a trim tab is fitted to the controls so the pilot is not worn out holding a course. Not only the small thing that turns the ship — the small thing that lets the one steering stop straining.

Push the swing. Someone pushing a child on a swing has the whole method in their hands: small force, matched to a rhythm that is already there, at the right moment, many times. Push out of time and the swing dies. Push harder out of time and it still dies. Almost all the energy in that arc is the swing's own; the hand only organises it. Your audience is the swing — its rhythms, its calendars, its memory, the people it already trusts — and the work is finding where it already moves.

Three things follow, and none of them is in the four promises below.

Choose your swing. You can push one swing deep or a whole playground shallow; you cannot do both, and every campaign that claims both is fooling itself. Funders' criteria usually ask whether you aim at mass reach or at targeted influence. That is not a trap; it is this choice, and the honest answer for most ideas is the narrow one — a few well-chosen people whose own audiences move with them. Say which you chose, out loud, so you know what to measure.

One swing at a time. Pushes that do not agree with each other cancel. Drop the same thing into five audiences at once, on five rhythms, and you have spent five inputs to produce nothing anyone can feel. One entry point, one rhythm, proven or failed, then the next.

The swing pushes back. If what comes back from the audience cannot change your work — its form, its subjects, its schedule — you were not pushing a swing. You were broadcasting with better manners. With, not for, is the same rule seen from the other side.

Four promises, and they only work together:

1. **Show it again.** Publish only what you can come back to, and put the return into the plan. The revisit is the argument.
2. **The person shown owns the showing.** Consent names how far it travels and how long it stays, before anything goes out. They can withdraw. They are a member of the thing, never its content.
3. **Show, don't tell.** No narrator, no ask, no caption drawing the conclusion. Doors, never a hand on the back.
4. **Say what failure looks like — out loud, in advance.** Predict the result, including the likely "nothing happened" after a single view. Let a hostile reader try to break it before you build it. A method that can't say what would disprove it is a belief.

Drop any one and you get something the world already has: lasting without ownership is surveillance; ownership without showing is a newsletter; showing without a failure test is faith.

And why four, not three: Esperanto has been lasting, owned, and self-demonstrating for over a century, and it never tipped — because nobody named what actually stops people (the cost of switching, and that too few others speak it). Three promises without the fourth still lose. That is what question 5 below is for.

What each side gives up. The method asks everyone to trade a comfort, and says so:

- The advocate gives up control — no narrator means no last word; giving the idea away means no ownership; an empty region held empty means patience over polish.
- The audience gives up the spectator's seat — the moment one real counter-example exists, "nothing can be done" stops being an excuse, and the next step (follow, twin, fund, visit) is theirs.
- The person shown gives up invisibility — only ever by their own named, informed, revocable step.

Five questions to ask your idea — the whole test:

1. Is there a real thing I can come back to?
2. Does the person shown own it, or am I using them?
3. Can it stand without a narrator?
4. What would tell me it isn't working?
5. What is the one belief actually stopping my audience — named, not guessed?

An example — a living map of places where something is growing: the point is the thing you come back to; membership follows the point; the sixty-second story has no narrator; the failure test lives in a group exercise; and the blocking belief is not hostility but futility — "nothing I do will change anything." Five for five. Your idea can be read the same way, and should be, before a funder does it for you.

Against a funder's list. Funders' criteria for advocacy work usually ask four things: safety (built so propaganda cannot turn the result against the people shown), no fakes, not a one-off action that fades in a week, and small budgets. This way of working meets all four by construction. The mass-reach-or-targeted question is answered by choosing your swing: targeted, and said out loud. It argues with one instinct: it is slow where criteria like fast. And it adds two things they rarely ask for: ownership for the people shown, and a failure test.

What it costs — honestly

- It is slow on purpose and loses every news cycle. It is the wrong tool for an emergency and does not pretend otherwise.
- It cannot prove the change it causes. Nothing in advocacy can. It at least says in advance what would show it failing.
- It grows only as fast as real consent conversations. There is no shortcut that does not break the second promise.
- In wartime, showing real people in real places has costs the people carry, not the campaign. Children never appear. Places blur to the district. Nothing goes out that could be turned against the person in it — and when in doubt, it stays off.

Take it

This is shared under a licence that lets you copy it, change it, rename it, and outgrow it. That is the point. The method's own first rule applies to the method: it is shown by use, not argued by its author. The five questions are the whole entry fee.

Where the numbers come from

Every figure in this guide is drawn from the full reference published alongside it, *Advocacy — Methods, Record, and a Trimtab Alternative*, which lists its sources by name in its §10. Nothing here is new; everything here is shorter.

Provenance

Derived from `whatif_guide_advocacy_UK_EN_v0_5.md` (v0.5) by `tools/build_oer_edition.py` on 2026-09-05. Removed for this edition: the initiative and jury under which the source was written, and the first instance it was read against; the source's changelog and drafting notes. The method, the record, every figure, and every source are unchanged. This edition is licensed CC BY-SA 4.0 and is written to be taken, changed, and outgrown.

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